SkillNavora

AI-FIRST PRODUCT MANAGEMENT · WEEK 6

# Effective Communication as a Product Manager

Lead without authority: structure your thinking, align every stakeholder, negotiate trade-offs and write documents people act on.






**Varun Kumar**
Founder & lead instructor, SkillNavora

TODAY

# What we'll cover

01 Communication is the job

02 A framework: audience, objective, approach

03 The three directions: team, upward, outer circle

04 Key documents and templates

05 Answer first: Pyramid, SCQA, BLUF, exec summaries

06 Storytelling: STAR, PREP and data

07 Stakeholder maps, RACI and DACI

08 Working with every function

09 Negotiation, conflict and difficult stakeholders

10 Meetings, PRDs and user stories

11 Feedback, exec reviews and bad news

12 AI for PM communication

13 Case study, assignment and interview prep

BEFORE WE START

# How this class works

### Ask anything

If a question blocks you, ask right away. Otherwise park it for the Q&A at the end.

### Focus on the message

Don't worry about every term. Slides and templates will be in your LMS after class.

### Be honest

Share real examples and real feedback. The anonymous class survey helps us improve.

### Practise live

We'll rewrite updates, map stakeholders and run a mock interview together.

### Bring your work

Use a product you know (your job or your favourite app) for every exercise.

### Have fun

Good communicators are curious and generous. Let's practise both.

PART 1

# 01 Communication is the job

Why the best PMs win on clarity, not on process.



FOUNDATIONS

# Why communication is the PM's core tool

PMs rarely have formal authority over the people who build, sell or support the product. Influence comes from **clarity, evidence, trust and consistency**.

> Most PM failures are communication failures: an unclear problem, an unshared trade-off, a surprise, or a decision nobody wrote down.

- **Start with the answer**, then support it
- **Know your audience**: what decision do they need to make?
- **Make trade-offs explicit**: options, cost, benefit, risk
- **Label** facts, assumptions and opinions
- **Write it down**: decisions, owners, dates
- **No surprises**: share bad news early, with a plan
- **Listen more than you talk**

MINDSET

# Two habits of great communicators

HABIT 1

## Extreme ownership

If the team misunderstood, the message wasn't clear enough. Own the outcome of every update: did the right people understand and act? Follow up until they do.

Ask after every important message: "Who needed to act, and did they?"

HABIT 2

## Audience empathy

Start from what the listener cares about, the words they use and the decision they face. An engineer, a CFO and a support lead need different versions of the same news.

Rewrite the first line for each audience before you send.

**Content over process.** Rituals, trackers and templates matter less than the substance: the problem, the evidence, the decision and the trade-off. Fix the content first; the process is a vehicle.

A SYSTEM

# Communication is a product system

Design every update the way you design a feature: for a user, with a goal, through the right channel, with a way to learn if it worked.

**Audience**
Who needs to act?

**Message**
What must be clear?

**Channel**
Where will it travel?

**Feedback**
How will you learn?



ACROSS THE LIFECYCLE

# What to communicate at each stage of a product

| Stage | Goal | Key artefacts | Main audience |
|---|---|---|---|
| Idea | Is this worth exploring? | One-pager, opportunity sizing | Manager, design, tech lead |
| Discovery | Understand the problem | User and market research doc | Core team, leadership |
| Definition | Agree what to build | PRD, designs, estimates | Engineering, design, data |
| MVP | Test the riskiest hypothesis | Experiment plan, progress updates, metrics | Core team, manager |
| Early launch | Prove value with more users | Project wiki, launch update, support FAQ | Partners, ops, support |
| General availability | Scale and win | Go-to-market plan, release notes, exec review | Marketing, sales, leadership |
| Growth | Keep improving | Experiment readouts, quarterly review | Leadership, whole company |

Each stage has a different question, so the documents and the audience change. Reuse: the one-pager becomes the PRD summary; the PRD becomes the launch FAQ.

PART 2

# 02 A framework for every message

Audience × objective × approach.

FRAMEWORK

# Audience, objective, approach

### 1 · Audience

- Core team (eng, design, data)
- Dependency teams
- Your manager and leadership
- Outer circle: ops, legal, support, marketing, sales
- Users and customers

### 2 · Objective

- **Educate**: share context
- **Learn**: get input or data
- **Influence**: change a view
- **Decide**: get a decision

### 3 · Approach

- **Content**: what to say, in what order
- **Channel**: doc, meeting, chat, demo
- **Cadence**: one-off, weekly, per release

Before any update, write one line: "I want **[audience]** to **[objective]**, so I'll **[approach]**." Example: "I want the Head of Payments to **decide** on the fee test, so I'll send a one-page brief 48 hours before Thursday's review."

CHANNELS

# Pick the channel by purpose and urgency

| Channel | Best for | Avoid for |
|---|---|---|
| Document (PRD, memo, wiki) | Complex reasoning, decisions, a record | Quick questions |
| Meeting | Debate, alignment, sensitive topics | Status that could be written |
| Chat (Slack, Teams) | Quick questions, coordination | Decisions, long debates, bad news |
| Async video (Loom) | Demos, walkthroughs across time zones | Anything that needs discussion |
| Dashboard | Metrics people check themselves | Explaining why something changed |
| Email / newsletter | Wide updates, external partners | Fast back-and-forth |

A useful rule: **decisions in documents, discussion in meetings, coordination in chat**. Then link the chat thread to the doc.

PART 3

# 03 The three directions

Your core team, upward to leadership, and the outer circle.



THREE DIRECTIONS

# Who you communicate with, and what they need




| Direction | Who | What they need |
|---|---|---|
| Immediate (core team) | Engineers, EMs, designers, analysts, data scientists | Goal, problem, scope, details, decisions |
| Upward | Manager, skip-level, executives, counterpart managers | Progress, risks, decisions needed, asks |
| Outer circle | Ops, legal, support, marketing, sales, finance, partners | Context early, their impact, timelines |

DIRECTION 1

# The immediate team: who, what and how

### Who

- Engineering manager and engineers
- Design manager and designers
- Analysts and data scientists
- QA and tech writers

### What

- Alignment on goal, problem and solution
- Solution design details
- Roadmap and effort estimates
- Sprint ceremonies: stand-ups, reviews, retros
- Data, research and insights

### How

- Working sessions (not status meetings)
- Docs, wikis, boards, dashboards
- Chat for quick questions
- Demos of work in progress

DIRECTION 1

# Best practices with your core team

### Involve them early

Share the why before the what. Engineers and designers often see the simplest solution.

### Define responsibilities

Who owns what (RACI) prevents confusion and finger-pointing later.

### Speak one language

Shared terms, a shared board and one source of truth for decisions.

### Set shared goals

Agree the outcome metric together so everyone pulls the same way.

### Protect focus

Batch questions, keep scope stable mid-sprint, and say no on their behalf.

### Celebrate and credit

Share wins with names in public updates. Own misses yourself.

DIRECTION 2

# Communicating upward

## Who

- Your manager and skip-level
- Executives and business leaders
- Managers of partner teams

## What they want

- Progress against goals, in numbers
- Risks early, with your plan
- Decisions they need to make, and by when
- Your judgement: recommendations, not lists

| 1:1 notes doc · [You] / [Manager] | |
|---|---|
| **Since last time** | Progress, wins, misses (looking back) |
| **Coming up** | Priorities for the next 2 weeks; align or adjust (looking forward) |
| **Help needed** | Decisions, blockers, introductions |
| **Workload** | How busy you are, so priorities stay realistic |
| **Manager's items** | What they want to discuss |
| **Growth (monthly)** | Career goals, feedback, skills to build |

> Keep one running doc, newest on top. It becomes the record for reviews and promotions.

DIRECTION 2

# The critical-issue update

| 🔴 Issue update · Payment failures · Update #2 · 14:00 IST | |
|---|---|
| **Status** | Ongoing · Severity 1 |
| **Impact** | ~8% of payments failing since 11:20; ~1,900 users affected |
| **Cause** | Gateway timeout after config change (confirmed) |
| **Actions** | Rolled back config at 13:40; failures dropping; retry banner live |
| **Next steps** | Monitor 2h; post-mortem Thursday |
| **Next update** | 16:00 IST, or sooner if anything changes |
| **Owner** | PM: Asha · Eng: Rohit |

- Send the first update fast, even if incomplete
- Same structure every time, so readers can scan
- Facts, then actions, then the next update time
- One owner; a single thread or channel
- Close it out: final update plus post-mortem link

> Hypothetical example.

DIRECTION 3

# The outer circle



## Best practices with non-technical partners

- **Set context early**, with a short pre-read
- **Repeat** your goal, roadmap and progress, again and again
- **Speak their language**: impact on their team, not tech details
- **Know their why**, and share yours
- **Be transparent** about risks and dates
- **Listen more than you talk**

DIRECTION 3

# A conversation with operations

**PM:** We're launching 15-minute grocery delivery in Pune next month. I'd like your view on what would make it work for your team.

**Head of Ops:** Honestly, our dark stores can't handle evening peaks yet.

**PM:** That's exactly what I need to know. If we launch in two pin codes first, with orders capped at 6–9 pm, could the stores keep up?

**Head of Ops:** Two pin codes, yes. I'd need 6 more pickers and a week of training.

**PM:** Let's put that in the launch plan. I'll share the forecast by Friday so you can hire, and we'll review peak-hour data together every week.

- Start from their constraint, not your plan
- Offer a smaller, safer first step
- Turn their needs into launch requirements
- Agree a shared review rhythm

> Illustrative, fictional scenario.

DIRECTION 3

# What each outer-circle partner cares about

| Partner | Key considerations |
| --- | --- |
| Operations | Operational impact, resourcing and staffing, risk, metrics, timelines |
| Legal & compliance | Regulation, data privacy and consent, claims in copy, contracts, IP |
| Customer support | User issues, training and help articles, changes to the product, feedback loop, success metrics |
| Product marketing | Positioning, unique selling points, segments, competitors, launch strategy, key metrics |
| Sales | Roadmap themes, deal blockers, honest timelines, what not to promise |
| Finance | Cost, revenue impact, pricing, budget timing |

PART 4

# 04 Key documents and templates

The artefacts that keep everyone aligned.

DOCUMENTS

# Key documents by audience

| Document | Purpose | Primary audience | Cadence |
|---|---|---|---|
| PRD | Problem, goals, scope, requirements | Core team | Per initiative; living |
| Jira / tracker | Work items, status, ownership | Core team | Daily |
| Project wiki | Single source of truth for the project | Core team, leaders | Updated continuously |
| Progress update | Status vs plan, risks, asks | Team, partners, managers | Weekly |
| Launch update | What shipped, for whom, how to measure | Partners, leadership, support | Per launch |
| 1:1 notes doc | Priorities, help, growth | Your manager | Each 1:1 |
| Critical-issue update | Impact, actions, next update | Partners, managers, leaders | During incidents |

TEMPLATE

# The project wiki: one source of truth

| Project wiki · Early fee display | |
|---|---|
| **Summary** | One paragraph: problem, goal, status |
| **Team & roles** | PM, EM, design, data; DACI for decisions |
| **Goals & metrics** | Primary metric, target, guardrails; dashboard link |
| **Timeline** | Milestones and dates; current stage |
| **Links** | PRD, designs, Jira epic, experiment plan |
| **Decision log** | Date · decision · who · why |
| **Risks & open questions** | Owner and due date for each |
| **Updates** | Newest weekly update on top |

- Audience: the working group plus relevant leaders
- Link out instead of copying, so nothing goes stale
- Anyone joining should get up to speed in 10 minutes
- Review it in every weekly sync

TEMPLATE

# The weekly progress update

| Weekly update · Early fee display · Week of 12 May | |
|---|---|
| **Overall** | 🟡 Amber: on track for the test, launch at risk by 1 week |
| **Progress** | Design done; 70% of build done; analytics events defined |
| **Metrics** | Not live yet; dashboard ready |
| **Risks** | Fee service latency at peak → fallback text agreed |
| **Decisions needed** | Legal wording for 'estimate' by Wednesday (owner: Legal) |
| **Next week** | QA, internal dogfood, experiment set-up |
| **Asks** | 1 QA engineer for 3 days |

- Lead with an honest red/amber/green status and why
- Show change since last week, not a full history
- Every risk gets an owner and a date
- Make asks specific: who, what, by when

> Hypothetical example.

TEMPLATE

# The launch update

| 🚀 Launched · Early fee display (A/B test) | |
|---|---|
| **What** | Cart now shows estimated total incl. fees, for 50% of users |
| **Why** | 30% of checkout starters left at payment; fee surprise was the top reason |
| **Who it affects** | First-time and returning buyers on Android and iOS |
| **How we'll measure** | Checkout completion (+2 pts target); complaint-rate guardrail |
| **Support** | Help article and 3 macros; tag: fee_estimate |
| **Thanks** | Design: Meera · Eng: Rohit, Sana · Data: Kabir |
| **Next** | Readout on 30 May; decision on full rollout |

- Send to partners, managers and support on launch day
- Explain the user value in one line
- Tell support exactly how to handle questions
- Credit the team by name

PART 5

# 05 Answer first

Structures that make your point land in seconds.

STRUCTURE

# The Pyramid Principle: answer first

**Recommendation: show the delivery fee in the cart this quarter**

### Biggest checkout leak

30% leave at payment

6 of 8 users cite fee surprise

### Cheap and low-risk

~2 person-months

Behind a feature flag

### We can prove it

A/B test, 14 days

Guardrail: complaints ≤ 1.3%

Lead with the governing thought, group reasons (MECE: no overlaps, no gaps), support each with evidence. A leader can stop at any level and still have the point. Example is hypothetical.

STRUCTURE

# SCQA: how to open any update, memo or pitch

**Situation**
Shared, uncontroversial context

**Complication**
What changed or what's wrong

**Question**
The question this raises

**Answer**
Your recommendation, then the pyramid

**Example. S:** Checkout completion is 70% and our biggest growth lever this quarter. **C:** 30% leave at payment, and users say the fee surprises them. **Q:** What should we change first? **A:** Show the full fee in the cart, tested as a two-week A/B experiment.

WRITING

# BLUF and writing for busy readers

## BLUF: bottom line up front

Put the conclusion or the ask in the first line, so a reader who stops there still knows what to do.

> **Subject:** Decision needed by Thu: approve 2-week fee test
> **BLUF:** I recommend we test early fee display for 2 weeks. I need your approval by Thursday.

## Writing checklist

- One idea per paragraph; short sentences
- Headings and bullets readers can scan
- Numbers with context (baseline, target, sample)
- Plain words; define any acronym once
- A clear ask with owner and date
- Your vision in one elevator-pitch line at the top of specs and decks

WRITING

# The executive summary: one screen, top of every doc

- **The ask**: the decision and the date
- **The recommendation**
- **Why**: 2–3 bullets with numbers
- **Risks** and how you'll handle them
- **What you need**: people, money, decision
- **What you're not doing**

**Decision needed by 15 May:** approve 2 engineers for 6 weeks to test early fee display.
**Recommendation:** A/B test; ship only if completion rises ≥ 2 points with no rise in complaints.
**Why:** payment step loses 30% of starters; 6/8 users cite fee surprise; est. +2,160 orders/month (range 720–4,320).
**Risks:** estimate inaccuracy → label as estimate, fallback text.
**Not doing:** loyalty redesign until Q3.

WRITING

# Narrative memos and PR/FAQs

NARRATIVE MEMO

## Think in full sentences

Some companies (Amazon popularised it) replace slides with a written memo read silently at the start of the meeting. Prose forces complete reasoning: claims, evidence and trade-offs can't hide behind bullets.

PR/FAQ

## Write the launch first

Before building, write a one-page press release from the customer's point of view, then the FAQs customers and leaders would ask. If the press release isn't exciting, rethink the idea.

STRUCTURE

# Pick the structure by audience and purpose

| Situation | Structure | Shape | Length |
|---|---|---|---|
| Recommendation to leadership | Pyramid + SCQA | Answer → reasons → evidence | 1 page / 3 min |
| Behavioural interview story | STAR | Situation → Task → Action → Result | 2 min |
| Opinion in a meeting or stand-up | PREP | Point → Reason → Example → Point | 30–60 s |
| Feedback to a colleague | SBI | Situation → Behaviour → Impact → ask | 2 min |
| Bad news or incident | 5 sentences | What · impact · cause · plan · next update | 1 message |

**PREP in a stand-up. Point:** delay the loyalty launch a week. **Reason:** payment errors tripled after Tuesday's release. **Example:** 412 failed attempts yesterday vs ~130 normally. **Point:** fix payments first, launch loyalty next Wednesday.

06

PART 6

# Storytelling

STAR, data and the stories people remember.

STORYTELLING

# STAR turns activity into a story

**Without STAR**

"We shipped a feature and users liked it."

**With STAR**

"Week-2 retention had fallen to 31%
**(S)**
. I had to bring it back without new engineering headcount
**(T)**
. We interviewed 12 churned users, simplified onboarding from 5 steps to 3 and added a progress nudge
**(A)**
. Retention rose to 36% in six weeks, measured in an A/B test
**(R)**
."

- **Situation**: context and the stakes, with a number
- **Task**: what you had to achieve, and the constraint
- **Action**: what *you* did (say "I", not only "we")
- **Result**: the measured outcome, or say it wasn't measured
- Add a one-line **learning**

> Use STAR in demos, leadership reviews and interviews. Hypothetical example.

STORYTELLING

# STAR in a team demo or leadership review

"Our onboarding was losing 35% of new users at step 2 **(S)**. We needed to improve activation without adding engineering scope **(T)**. We rewrote two screens, tested two tooltip versions and removed one mandatory field **(A)**. In two weeks activation rose 19% with only copy and configuration changes **(R)**."

### Data

The number that shows the problem and the result.

### Emotion

A user quote or moment that makes it real.

### Clarity

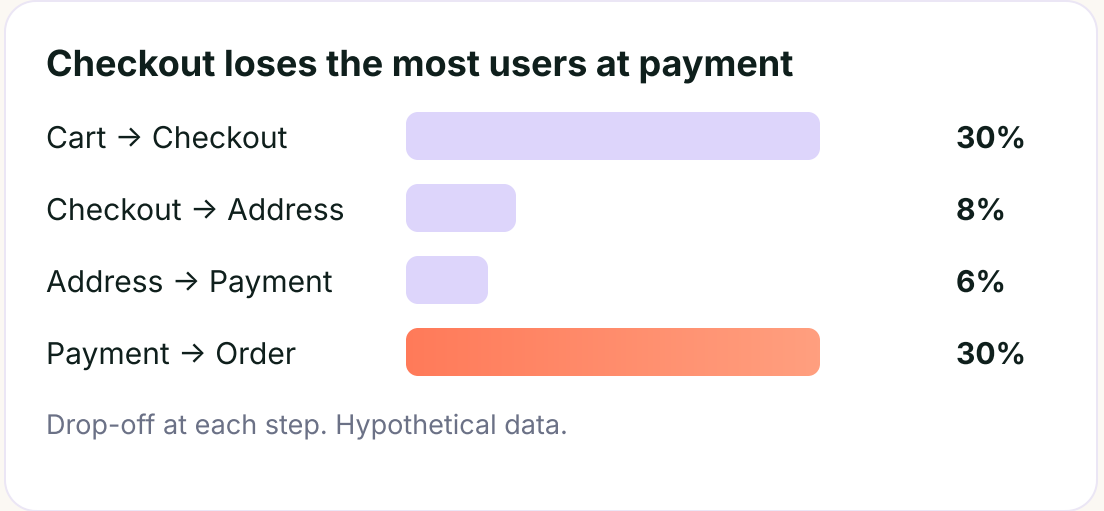
One message the audience can repeat.

Hypothetical example. Data + emotion + clarity = a story people remember and retell.

DATA

# Storytelling with data

- **Title = takeaway**: "Checkout loses most users at payment", not "Funnel Q1"
- **Right chart**: trend → line, comparison → bar, distribution → histogram
- **Remove clutter**; highlight one thing with colour
- **Give context**: baseline, target, sample size
- **Show uncertainty**: ranges, not false precision
- **End with the action** you want



PART 7

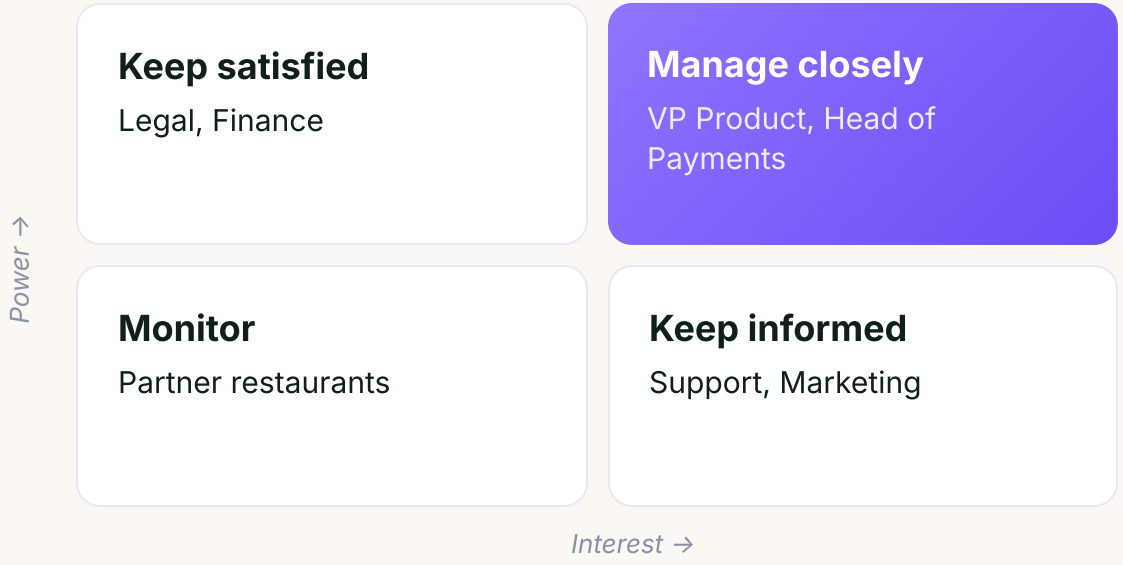
# 07 Stakeholders and decision rights

Map who matters and make it clear who decides.



STAKEHOLDERS

# Map who matters: the power–interest grid




- **High power, high interest**: partner closely; bring options, not surprises
- **High power, low interest**: short, decision-focused updates
- **Low power, high interest**: keep informed; make progress easy to follow
- Re-map as the project changes; Legal can block a launch late if ignored

> Hypothetical placement for a checkout redesign.

DECISION RIGHTS

# RACI and DACI: who decides?

## RACI (for work)

- **Responsible**: does the work
- **Accountable**: one owner of the outcome
- **Consulted**: two-way input
- **Informed**: kept updated

## DACI (for decisions)

- **Driver** runs the process
- **Approver**: one person decides
- **Contributors** give input
- **Informed** hear the result

| Role | Who (example) |
|---|---|
| Driver | PM, Checkout |
| Approver | Head of Product |
| Contributors | Design, Eng lead, Analytics, Payments, Legal |
| Informed | Support, Marketing, Sales |

> One approver per decision. Writing this down before the debate prevents most escalations. Once decided, **disagree and commit**: everyone backs the decision, and the dissent is noted.

INFLUENCE

# Influence without authority: what actually works

**Shared goals**
"We both want fewer failed payments."

**Evidence**
Data, research and customer quotes beat opinions.

**Reciprocity**
Help others hit their goals too.

**Early involvement**
People defend what they helped write.

**Follow-through**
Do what you said. Credibility compounds.

**Easy yes**
Clear asks and small first steps.

COLLABORATION

# Working with every function

| Partner | They need from you | You need from them | Common friction |
|---|---|---|---|
| Engineering | Clear problem, stable scope, early involvement | Estimates, risks, options | Late changes; dates set without them |
| Design | Problem, evidence, time to explore | Flows, prototypes, research | Solution-first requests |
| Data | Decisions and tracking needs early | Definitions, analysis, experiments | Ad-hoc asks with no decision |
| Marketing | Positioning, dates, user value | Messaging, launch plan | Late notice; overpromising |
| Sales | Roadmap themes, honest timelines | Customer feedback, deal blockers | Promising features to close deals |
| Support | Release notes, known issues | Ticket trends, pain points | Launching without readiness |
| Legal | Early sight of data and claims | Risk review, approvals | Brought in at the last minute |

ENGINEERING

# Negotiating scope with an engineering lead

**PM:** Our goal is to stop the fee surprise for first-time buyers this quarter. What's the simplest version you'd build?

**Eng lead:** A static fee is easy. A live estimate needs the pricing service: three weeks, and it's flaky at peak.

**PM:** What if v1 shows the estimate when the service replies within 500 ms, and 'Estimate unavailable' otherwise?

**Eng lead:** Then it's about ten days. We'd add a cache later.

**PM:** Let's take that, behind a flag, as an A/B test. I'll update the PRD and log the cache as a follow-up.

- **Goal first**, not a solution
- **Ask for the simplest option**
- **Estimates as ranges** with assumptions
- **Trade scope, not quality**
- **Record the follow-up**
- Story points are team planning tools, not productivity scores

Illustrative dialogue.

08

PART 8

# Negotiation and conflict

Find the interests behind the positions.

NEGOTIATION

# Positions vs interests

**Sales position**
"Build custom reports for Client X by June."

**Product position**
"Not this quarter, checkout comes first."

**Sales interest**
Keep a ₹40 lakh renewal; the client's finance team needs monthly numbers.

**Product interest**
Hit the checkout goal; avoid one-off custom features.

**Options that serve both**
Scheduled CSV export in 2 weeks now · custom reports evaluated in Q3 with evidence from other clients.

From *Getting to Yes* (Fisher & Ury): separate people from the problem, focus on interests, invent options, use objective criteria, know your BATNA. Example is hypothetical.

CONFLICT

# Resolving conflict

## Five conflict modes (Thomas–Kilmann)

- **Collaborating**: important, high-trust issues
- **Compromising**: time-bound trade-offs
- **Accommodating**: low stakes, build goodwill
- **Competing**: urgent, clear-cut calls
- **Avoiding**: trivia only

## A five-step sequence

1. Restate each side's interest until they agree you understood
2. Agree the shared goal and decision criteria
3. Lay out options with evidence
4. Decide, or escalate together with a joint summary
5. Document and move on

STAKEHOLDERS

# Difficult stakeholders: patterns and responses

| Pattern | Response |
| --- | --- |
| The HiPPO (highest-paid person's opinion) | Ask for the goal behind the idea; propose a test; show data respectfully |
| The bulldozer ("just build it") | Acknowledge urgency; show the cost of delay of displaced work; offer a smaller slice |
| The silent blocker | 1:1 conversation; ask what would make them comfortable; involve them early |
| The scope-creeper | Point to the agreed scope and decision log; queue new asks for the next cycle |
| The customer-promiser | Shared rule: no commitments without PM sign-off; share themes, not dates |

PART 9

# 09 Meetings and product documents

Make meetings decide, and documents align.

MEETINGS

# The types of communication a PM runs

| Format | Purpose | Make it work |
|---|---|---|
| 1:1s | Trust, priorities, growth | Shared notes doc; the other person's agenda first |
| Team syncs | Coordination and blockers | Agenda in advance; decisions and owners at the end |
| Stand-ups | Daily unblocking | 15 minutes; problems taken offline |
| Docs (PRDs, memos) | Reasoning and decisions | Summary on top; comments resolved |
| Feature pitches | Get buy-in for an idea | SCQA opening; problem before solution |
| Status updates | Visibility | RAG status, change since last time, asks |
| Research synthesis | Share what users told us | Insights with evidence and quotes |
| Design reviews | Feedback on a solution | Review against the problem and principles, not taste |
| Leadership reviews | Decisions and alignment | Pre-read, decisions needed, hardest questions answered |

MEETINGS

# Anatomy of a decision meeting

**Pre-read (T−48h)**
1-page brief: context, options, recommendation

**Frame · 5 min**
Decision, decider, criteria

**Options · 15 min**
Trade-offs and evidence

**Dissent · 10 min**
"What would make this wrong?"

**Decide · 5 min**
Or name the missing information

**Record (T+24h)**
Decision, rationale, owner, review date

Share an agenda before every meeting and a summary with action items after it. If nobody read the pre-read, read it together for the first five minutes.

DOCUMENTS

# The PRD: a living alignment tool

**1 · Summary & decision**
Problem, proposal, impact; owner, status

**2 · Problem & evidence**
Who, what task, why it's hard; data and quotes

**3 · Goals & metrics**
Primary metric and target; guardrails

**4 · Users & use cases**
Segments, key scenarios, edge cases

**5 · Scope**
In and out of scope; assumptions

**6 · Requirements**
User stories, acceptance criteria, non-functional

**7 · Design & analytics**
Prototype links; tracking plan

**8 · Launch & risks**
Rollout, flags, rollback; open questions

**Learn from real PRDs:** read public PRD templates and examples from companies such as Atlassian, Figma and Lenny's Newsletter, and compare how they handle goals, metrics and scope. Use AI for a first draft, never as the source of truth.

DOCUMENTS

# User stories and acceptance criteria

> **User story.** As a first-time buyer, I want to see my estimated total in the cart, so that I can decide before I start paying.

## INVEST checklist

Independent · Negotiable · Valuable · Estimable · Small · Testable

## One-pager before a PRD

Problem, why now, who, approach, impact range, cost, risks, the ask. If it doesn't fit on one page, the idea isn't clear yet.

## Acceptance criteria (Given / When / Then)

- **Given** an eligible address, **when** the cart opens, **then** show item price, estimated fees, taxes and total.
- **Given** the fee service fails, **when** the cart loads, **then** show "Estimate unavailable" and a Retry button, and never show an invented fee.
- **Given** the address changes, **when** the cart reloads, **then** refresh the estimate within 2 seconds (p95).

PART 10

# 10 Feedback and leadership communication

Keep the loop open; deliver bad news well.



FEEDBACK

# Feedback is a loop, not an event

## SBI: Situation · Behaviour · Impact

> "In yesterday's review **(S)**, the PRD's success metric changed from completion to clicks without a note **(B)**. Engineering built tracking for the old metric and lost a day **(I)**. Could we add a change log to the PRD?"

**Receiving feedback:** thank, clarify, don't defend in the moment, decide what to act on, close the loop.

| 1 · Context | 2 · Response | 3 · Action | 4 · Close |
|---|---|---|---|
| Be specific | Listen fully | Agree the next step | Follow up |



CADENCE

# Keep every audience informed

| Audience | Format | Cadence | Contents |
|---|---|---|---|
| Leadership | One-page update | Weekly / fortnightly | Metrics vs target, decisions needed, risks |
| Partners | Channel post + sync | Weekly | Progress, blockers, upcoming asks |
| Support & sales | Release notes + FAQ | Per release | What changed, how to explain it, known issues |
| Whole company | Demo / newsletter | Monthly | Outcomes and learnings |
| Anyone affected by an incident | Incident message | Now, then on a schedule | Impact, plan, next update time |

LEADERSHIP

# Executive reviews and delivering bad news

## What executives want

- The **decision** you need
- How it serves the **strategy**
- **Metrics vs targets**, with honest green/amber/red
- **Learnings**: what surprised you, what you stopped
- What you're **not doing**
- Anticipate the **three hardest questions**

## Bad news in five sentences

1. What happened, plainly
2. The impact
3. The cause (if known)
4. What you're doing, and what you need
5. When you'll update next

> "The launch will slip two weeks. A payment-gateway certification took longer than estimated. No customer-facing risk. I recommend waiting rather than launching without the new payment method. I'll update you every Friday."

PART 11

# 11 AI for PM communication

Faster drafts, better clarity, your judgement.

AI

# Use AI to communicate better, not to think less

## Good uses

- Turn messy notes into a structured update
- Rewrite one message for three audiences
- Summarise research or long threads
- Find gaps: "What would an engineer ask?"
- Draft STAR stories from your notes
- Check tone before sending difficult messages

## Ground rules

- Never paste confidential or personal data into public tools
- Check every number, name and claim
- AI drafts; you decide and own the message
- Keep your own voice; edit generic phrasing

> Claude, ChatGPT and Gemini are all useful here. Use your company's approved tool for work data.

AI PROMPTS

# Prompts you can use this week

### STAR story

```
Turn these notes into a STAR story for a PM interview. Keep my actions specific, use only the numbers I give, and flag anything missing: [notes]
```

### Pyramid rewrite

```
Rewrite this update using the Pyramid Principle: recommendation first, then 3 reasons with evidence, then the ask. Under 120 words: [update]
```

### Audience versions

```
Write three versions of this launch note: for engineers (details), for leadership (impact and risks) and for support (what to tell customers): [note]
```

### Stress test

```
Act as a sceptical CFO. List the 5 hardest questions you'd ask about this proposal and what evidence would convince you: [proposal]
```

### Meeting summary

```
Summarise this meeting transcript into decisions, owners, dates and open questions. Do not invent anything: [transcript]
```

PART 12

# 12 Practice, case study and interview prep

Apply everything from today.

PRACTICE

# Exercise: rewrite this update

## Original

> "We did lots of analysis this week. We looked at funnels, did interviews, talked to payments, and engineering thinks it's 2 months. Fees might be a problem. Also loyalty is pending."

## Your turn (5 minutes)

Rewrite it with the Pyramid Principle: answer first, then 2–3 reasons with evidence, then the ask.

## Model answer

> **Recommendation:** test showing the delivery fee in the cart from next sprint. **Why:** (1) 30% of checkout starters leave at payment; (2) 6 of 8 interviewees cite fee surprise; (3) a simplified v1 takes ~2 weeks (full live estimate ~2 months). **Ask:** approve the two-week v1 and an A/B test; loyalty moves to Q3.

CASE STUDY

# Rising cancellations at a home-services app

**FixRight** (a fictional home-services app for cleaning, plumbing and repairs) has seen booking cancellations rise from 9% to 15% over three months. The CEO wants a recommendation in Friday's leadership review.

## In groups (15 minutes)

1. Who are your stakeholders? Map them on a power–interest grid
2. Which data would you pull, and from whom?
3. Write the SCQA opening for Friday's review
4. Draft the one-page update: findings, options, recommendation, asks

## Hints

- Split cancellations by who cancels: customer or professional
- Look by category, city, time to job and price shown vs final
- Talk to support and ops: they hear the reasons first
- Separate facts, assumptions and next experiments
- End with a clear ask and the next update date

THIS WEEK

# Assignment

1. **PRD**: **FitCircle**, a fictional fitness app, wants streaks, rewards and friend challenges to improve 30-day retention. Write a PRD for design and engineering using the template in your LMS.
2. **Executive summary**: one screen recommending the launch plan, for the CEO.
3. **Stakeholder map**: six stakeholders on a power–interest grid, one action each.
4. **Launch update**: the message you'd send on launch day.

Submit in your LMS under **Week 6**. Written feedback before next week's class.

## What good looks like

- Problem and evidence before features
- One primary metric plus guardrails (e.g. no rise in injuries or uninstalls)
- Clear scope: in, out, later
- Testable acceptance criteria
- Risks: fairness, cheating, notification fatigue

INTERVIEW PREP

# Communication questions PM interviewers ask

| Question | What they're testing | Answer outline |
|---|---|---|
| Tell me about a time you influenced without authority | Influence, evidence, empathy | STAR; shared goal, data, options; real result |
| Describe a conflict with engineering. How did you resolve it? | Conflict handling, respect | Both sides' interests; options; decision; relationship after |
| How would you tell executives a launch is delayed? | Bad news, ownership | 5 sentences; options with a recommendation; next update |
| How do you handle a stakeholder who keeps adding scope? | Prioritisation, boundaries | Goal, cost of delay, decision log, next cycle |
| How do you keep a large cross-functional project aligned? | Systems thinking | Project wiki, weekly update, DACI, rituals |
| Walk me through a PRD you wrote | Clarity, structure | Problem, evidence, metrics, scope, trade-offs, what you'd change |
| Sales promised a feature to a client. What do you do? | Judgement, partnership | Understand the interest; options; shared rule for the future |
| How do you explain a technical trade-off to a non-technical leader? | Translation | Impact first, analogy, options, recommendation |

INTERVIEW PREP

# Model answer: "Describe a conflict with engineering"

**S:** Two weeks before a launch, our tech lead wanted to delay by a sprint to fix performance; sales had already announced the date. **T:** I needed a decision that protected users without losing the launch. **A:** I met the tech lead 1:1 to understand the risk, which was slow load times for 20% of Android users. I asked for options: we found we could launch to iOS and high-end Android first and fix performance behind a flag. I wrote a one-page options note and took it to my manager and the sales lead together. **R:** We launched on time to 80% of users; the rest followed 9 days later with no complaints spike. **Learning:** bring options, not positions.

Hypothetical model answer: use your own real story and numbers.

## Do

- Say "I" for your actions
- Show you understood the other side
- Give the measured result, or say it wasn't measured
- End with what you learned

## Don't

- Blame the other team
- Invent numbers
- Tell a story where you simply escalated

INTERVIEW PREP

# A 60-second story bank

Prepare five stories before any PM interview. Each one can answer many questions.

1. A decision you made with incomplete data
2. A trade-off you negotiated
3. A stakeholder conflict you resolved
4. A launch or project that went wrong, and what you learned
5. A result you are proud of, with numbers

## Practise

- Write each as STAR in under 150 words
- Say it aloud in 60–90 seconds
- Prepare follow-ups: "What would you do differently?"
- Practise with AI as the interviewer, then with a peer
- Book a mock interview in your LMS

> Interviewers often ask for one decision story, one trade-off, one conflict and one measurable result.

SUMMARY

# Key takeaways

**Communication is the job**
Own the outcome of every message; start from your audience.

**Audience · objective · approach**
Pick content, channel and cadence on purpose.

**Three directions**
Core team, upward and outer circle need different things.

**Answer first**
Pyramid, SCQA and BLUF; MECE reasons with evidence.

**Stories that stick**
STAR for stories, PREP for quick points, data with a takeaway title.

**Decision rights**
RACI/DACI, written decisions, disagree and commit.

**Interests over positions**
Negotiate with options and objective criteria.

**Living documents**
PRD, wiki, weekly and launch updates keep everyone aligned.

**No surprises**
Share bad news early with a plan and the next update time.

CHEAT SHEET

# Before you hit send

- ☐ Who must act, and is it clear in the first line?
- ☐ Is the answer or ask up front (BLUF)?
- ☐ Are facts, assumptions and opinions labelled?
- ☐ Is every number in context?
- ☐ Is there an owner and a date for each ask?
- ☐ Is this the right channel?
- ☐ Would this surprise anyone? Tell them first.



## Questions?

support@skillnavora.in · www.skillnavora.in

Further reading: Barbara Minto, *The Pyramid Principle* · Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic, *Storytelling with Data* · Fisher, Ury & Patton, *Getting to Yes* · Atlassian DACI playbook · CCL SBI feedback model · Sachin Rekhi, *Mastering effective communication as a PM*.